Article

Improving Schools
15(3) 185–197
© The Author(s) 2012
Reprints and permission:
sagepub.co.uk/journalsPermissions.nav
DOI: 10.1177/1365480212461824
imp.sagepub.com

'Why didn't they ask me?': Student perspectives on a school improvement initiative

Lesley Scanlon
University of Sydney, Australia

Abstract

This is the first in a series of articles which will examine the results of a qualitative, longitudinal study of school improvement initiatives from the perspective of school stakeholders. The article captures the responses of students from a low socio-economic status school in NSW, Australia to a school initiative that restructured the learning and teaching environment of the senior school. This initiative, undertaken in the context of high stakes testing and public accountability, aimed to 'break the cultural mould' of poor attendance, retention and below state average examination results in the senior school. After explaining the senior school restructure, the article briefly reviews the literature on cultural change and student voice within the context of school improvement. The qualitative methodology is examined and this is followed by an exploration of the findings where students identify the salient dimensions of the initiative which had an impact on their learning and teaching environment. The discussion examines the findings within the context of the research literature of school improvement, cultural change and transition.

Keywords

change, culture, senior school, student voice

Introduction

Grange High in NSW, Australia is currently engaged in a range of school improvement initiatives under the Federal Government National Partnership Agreement on Low Socio-Economic School (SES) Communities. A three-year longitudinal research project is currently examining the initiatives from multiple stakeholder perspectives: the school executive, teachers, students and parents. The research acknowledges that significant changes, such as those at Grange, have no reality outside of the perception of local actors (Fullan, 1992). Through the conceptual framework of cultural change and transition this article explores a senior school initiative from the perspective of the first two cohorts of senior students. This initiative caused significant changes to annual and daily

Corresponding author:
Lesley Scanlon, Director of Professional Doctorates, Faculty of Education and Social Work, University of Sydney, Sydney, NSW 2006, Australia.
Email: lesley.scanlon@sydney.edu.au

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

learning and teaching schedules in the senior school. It is important to give voice to students when evaluating school improvement initiatives because, as McGregor (2011) points out, their voices are rarely heard because it is adults who constantly speak about and for young people. The student perspective on this initiative is also intrinsically interesting because first, the initiative was intended to improve their learning experiences through cultural change and second, because, as Fullan (1992, p. 7) remarks, students have made a career of resisting change through 'opportunistic assimilation'. Resistance to change is to be expected and Fullan (1992) observes the greater the internal turbulence the greater the intrinsic change and the greater chance of actually achieving outcomes. Engaging students in improvement initiatives through a partnership approach may encourage students to 'buy into' reform initiatives and cooperate more fully in achieving the proposed outcomes.

Research context

Grange High is a comprehensive government secondary school with an enrolment of some 500 students and is situated in NSW, Australia, in an area of significant unemployment and socio-economic disadvantage. Over recent years Grange, like many such schools, has been the recipient of Federal government funds in a range of government educational programmes. The most recent example is partnership funding instituted by the Federal Labor government in 2009 to support the government's *Quality education: The case for an education revolution in our schools* (Rudd & Gillard, 2008). With funds from the partnership scheme, Grange introduced a number of improvement measures which focused on providing innovations in learning and teaching and tailoring learning opportunities for students.

This article reports on the initial findings of one of these initiatives: the New Model senior school. This initiative has restructured the learning and teaching environment in which students study for the Higher School Certificate examination (HSC). This examination is the final secondary school examination in NSW and an example of 'high stakes testing' where test scores not only have significance for students but also for teachers and schools. This is particularly so following the launch of the Federal Government's My School website in January 2010 which enables public scrutiny and comparison of schools. Current My School data indicates that Grange is in the bottom 15 percent of the state in literacy, numeracy and HSC results. In the current project it is not suggested that the school improvement initiatives were launched only because of external pressure, nonetheless, new surveillance measures and public reporting played a role in the desire to 'break the cultural mould and try to get a different result' (member of Senior School Executive) by improving student engagement, attendance and retention.

The initiative

In most schools in NSW students study for the HSC in what I refer to in this article as the 'Traditional Model' first introduced following the Wyndham Report in 1959, with the first HSC in 1967. In this model the senior school consists of Years 11 and 12 with students sitting for examinations in six subjects at the completion of Year 12. In the New Model students sit for examinations in three subjects at the completion of Senior Year 1 and the final three subjects at the completion of Senior Year 2. This model deviates from mainstream practice and hence schools must obtain permission from the Board of Studies (BoS) which oversees curriculum in NSW (Table 1).

Students in the New Model receive the same number of in-class teaching hours as in the 'Traditional Model'. At Grange this has been achieved through significant rescheduling of the school day with

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

Table 1. Comparison of Traditional and New Model HSC structure

Traditional Model	New Model
Years 11 & 12	Senior Years 1 & 2
HSC exam, 6 subjects Year 12	3 HSC subjects Senior Year 1 3 HSC subjects Senior Year 2
50-minute lessons	2-hour lessons
Year 11 & 12 separate classes	Composite Senior Years 1 & 2

senior lessons extended from 50-minute blocks to two-hour blocks. The school executive is hopeful that the 'New Model' will improve student retention because of reduced subject load in each of the senior years and the reduction of examination stress following the introduction of the two-step mode of examination. Another feature of the New Model is the 'rollover' in which students begin their senior studies in the last four weeks of the academic year in Year 10. These four weeks are followed by the summer vacation after which senior students return to school and immediately resume, rather than begin, senior studies.

Literature

The research in which this article is embedded is situated in what Hopkins and Reynolds (2001) refer to as 'the third phase' of school improvement. In this phase improvement is concerned with student outcomes, classroom processes, capacity building and professional development. The student outcomes and classroom processes targeted in the initiative reviewed here resulted in significant cultural change to the senior school. It is for this reason that the conceptual framework of the research draws on a sociological perspective of cultural change and transition. All contemporary improvement initiatives are embedded within a global environment of accountability and performativity, an environment in which Reezigt and Cremmers (2005) comment student outcomes are openly published and place schools in a position where they are 'forced' to undertake improvement measures. Improvement implies change and change which impacts on school culture is the most difficult to sustain, argues Barth (2002), because changing 'the way we do things around here' implies fundamental modifications to daily routines and rituals as well as challenging long-held values and belief systems.

What makes cultural change even more difficult is the fact that organizations have multiple cultures. For example, school culture includes the sub-cultures of students, teachers, faculty, and executive cultures. These cultures are themselves multi-layered, constructed through multiple discourses in different contexts such as the classroom, the staffroom, individual faculties and the playground. These multiple school cultures are an example of what Holstein and Gubrium (2000, p. 161) refer to as 'local culture', localized ways of understanding and representing things and actions and of assigning meaning to lives. If there is an assault on local culture this may, according to Stolp and Smith (1995), result in anxiety and antagonism for the inhabitants of that culture.

Cultural change requires those embedded within the culture to make a transition from the old to the new. These transitions are always difficult because, for example, students transitioning from junior high school to senior school only have 'knowledge about' (Schutz, 1970, p. 93) the senior culture from observations and conversations with senior students who themselves have 'knowledge of' the senior culture through their own experiences. Thus, incoming students have cultural expectations that frame their identity as senior students. Indeed the rehearsal of 'possible selves'

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

prior to transition into a new cultural environment can assist in bridging the gap between two cultures (Markus & Nurius, 1986). However, if the context of transition is unexpectedly shifted these expectations of identity, which are always specific to situations according to Baumeister and Muraven (1996), are disrupted adding to the dislocation associated with transition. (The use of 'possible selves' as a mechanism for coping with the disruptions associated with transition is examined in Scanlon, Rowling, & Weber [2007] and Scanlon [2011].)

Anderson, Jacobs, Schramm, and Splittgerber (2000) argue that transitions interrupt the continuity of life, pointing to organizational and social discontinuities associated with transition in educational institutions. Organizational discontinuity involves changes to tracking, standards and teacher expectations while social discontinuity is about the student demographic, a sense of belonging and relationships with teachers. When transition is too difficult and students cannot embed themselves in the new community they frequently 'drop out' as 'an act of rejecting the community' (Roderick, 1993, p. 329, cited in Anderson et al., 2000, p. 329). It is also important to ensure that there is not a mismatch between students' out-of-school life as a burgeoning self-determined adult and their in-school life where there are few opportunities for self-determination (Demetriou, Goalen, & Rudduck, 2000). School structures frequently offer students less responsibility and autonomy than they experience outside of school (Rudduck, 2001).

To enhance the chances of successful introduction and implementation of school improvement measures which have culture implications it is necessary to include all stakeholders. This need for all stakeholders to 'buy in' (Levin, 2000) to school improvement initiatives is a theme running through the school improvement literature (for example, Demetriou & Wilson, 2010). The stakeholders whose day-to-day learning and teaching experiences are most affected by school change are students and teachers, however, students as key stakeholders are frequently excluded from consultative processes. Stoll and Fink (1994, 1996), for example, found that teachers generally do not consider students as partners in improvement; their inclusion as valued participants and indeed as partners in school change is a key element in what Hargreaves and Shirley (2009) call 'the fourth wave' of school improvement. However, students remain the most neglected stakeholders; they are seen as the targets and intended beneficiaries of change rather than as participants in the change process itself (Leitch & Mitchell, 2007). A key reason why the student voice is silenced has to do with what Grace (1995, p. 202) calls 'the ideology of immaturity' which encourages the view that students do not have the required developmental level to make meaningful contributions to change situations which impact on their own learning. In contemporary society this is an outmoded view of young people who, Rudduck and Flutter (2000) remind us, have increased responsibilities and perform multiple roles in their out-of-school lives and yet have little say in how they learn and how they are taught. This runs contrary to contemporary, constructivist pedagogies and democratic citizenship both of which emphasize participation in decision-making. When students express opinions teachers often do not have the time to listen because of the demands of the regimes of 'performativity' (Fielding, 2001). A further complication of course is that there is no one student voice.

What can be gained by consulting students? Levin (2000) points out that student involvement is fundamental to any reform because they have unique knowledge and perspectives; it is students who produce school outcomes targeted by reforming initiatives. In terms of classroom learning students are 'expert witnesses' (Rudduck & Flutter, 2000, p. 81) and 'the treasure in our very own backyards' (Soo Hoo, 1993, p. 389, cited in Demetriou & Wilson, 2010, p. 55) in terms of classroom learning. It is from stories students tell us about individual lessons that educators and instigators of reform can glean broader curriculum insights (Rudduck & Flutter, 2000). Moreover, Demetriou and Wilson (2010) note that students should be listened to because they will feel

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

respected, have greater control of the pace of learning and teaching and so will feel more positive. Furthermore, students can also help mobilize parents and teachers in favour of meaningful reform by pointing out to educators what helps them learn or gets in the way of their learning and what the school might do to increase the opportunities for learning (Levin, 2000; Zion, 2009). Additionally, because Australia is a signatory nation to the Convention on the Rights of the Child (1990) it follows that Australian schools have an obligation to consult young people in matters that have a significant impact on their learning.

Methodology

School improvement research has used qualitative research approaches unlike the quantitative methodology of school evaluation (Lingard, 2005). To capture student perspectives of the senior school change this qualitative research is grounded in symbolic interactionism and the phenomenological sociology of Alfred Schutz popularized by Berger and Luckmann in *The social construction of reality* in 1966. This methodological approach focuses the researcher on first order constructs, that is, the situated phenomena identified by the research participants. To do this, the researcher adopts the attitude of what Schutz referred to as 'the disinterested attitude of the scientific observer' (Schutz, 1970, p. 44). The adoption of such an attitude requires the researcher to bracket out their own presuppositions in order to enter the world of the research participants. The epistemological stance consistent with this symbolic interactionist approach is constructivism which describes how individuals interact with objects in the world and how they make sense of these objects (Crotty, 1998). Symbolic interaction as a methodological perspective, Woods (1996) argues, enables the educational researcher to understand what students make of what is being offered to them and how they feel about the circumstances in which it is offered. It thus provides a lens through which to glimpse students' understandings of school initiatives, for example.

In order to access these understandings iterative semi-structured interviews of 30–60 minutes duration were conducted with 40 volunteers from the first two cohorts of the New Model senior students. These students were those who returned consent forms signed by parents or guardians. Through the interviews the hitherto invisible world of the students has been rendered visible to school policy-makers and through this article to the broader educational community. Students' lived experiences of the New Model emerged through an iterative reading of the transcripts which identified key themes in each person's telling of their experiences. Key themes across the transcripts were then identified. It is these themes which structure the research findings section below. (Pseudonyms are used throughout the article for the school and students. 'New Model' and associated terminologies used in the article are not used in any formal nomenclature and have been adopted to enhance anonymity.)

Research findings

At Grange 'New Model' and its associated terminologies (Senior Year 1 and Senior Year 2) is the nomenclature adopted by the executive and some of the teaching staff, however, many more of the staff and students continue to use the nomenclature of the traditional system (Year 11 and Year 12). Students and some teachers also frequently refer to the previous HSC model as 'normal', 'the usual' or 'traditional'. It was the loss of the traditional school senior culture and its associated privileges that was a constant refrain in interviews with these first two cohorts of senior students.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

> Everything has changed for us . . . so we are the disadvantaged ones . . . we miss out on everything . . . which is really unfair because we've worked hard.

The majority of students felt that long-awaited entitlements, for which they believed they had worked throughout the junior school, had been taken from them. The conceptual framework of cultural change and transition has been used to structure the presentation of students' perceptions in this section of the article. The senior students' transitional journey into the new alien culture of the senior school is explored through four major dimensions identified by them, the first is the consultative dimension, this is followed by the transitional dimension, then the status dimension and finally the learning dimension.

The consultative dimension

Students felt they were told rather than consulted about changes to their senior school. Being consulted about a significant change to their final years at school was an expectation of students that was not actualized in the schools' introduction and implementation of the New Model; this lack of consultation had an impact on students' perceptions of the improvement measure. Students in the final term of Year 10 learned of the changes to the senior school in an information session conducted by the school principal. Until that time they anticipated transitioning to the senior high school of traditional school folklore, extant for over 40 years. All of the students interviewed commented on the lack of prior consultation – 'why didn't they ask me?', 'we didn't expect it'; students felt they were being 'forced into it', that the school executive had not canvassed student opinion. Many students expressed significant dismay with the New Model – 'how could they . . . this is horrible . . . they are so stupid . . . they don't know what they're doing'. Other students commented, 'we hated it', 'we were angry', 'it is really confusing', and 'this is stuffed'. On first hearing of the change to their senior school experience the word 'bummed' was most frequently used by students to describe their negative response.

The transitional dimension

The folklore of the senior school prepared Year 10 students for a long summer vacation prior to embarking on their senior studies in the new calendar year. It did not prepare students for the early 'rollover' into the senior school at the end of Year 10. Many students at Grange, and other schools, had previously extended the summer vacation by 'truanting' for the final four weeks of Year 10 and thus extending their holidays. The widespread occurrence of this form of absenteeism is evidenced in local newspaper stories of Year 10 students on the beach rather than attending school. The loss of this social aspect which marked the end of junior school was a poignant reminder that New Model students were unlike previous senior students and were not like other senior students in neighbouring schools – 'my friends at other schools went to the beach every day . . . others just chill at home playing games'. Another student expressed his dissatisfaction thus:

> I wasn't very happy. I needed a break to relax and everything. I thought it was pretty stupid my friends got the rest of the year off and I had to start early.

There were students however who whilst they were not particularly happy with the early return to school studies made comments such as, 'I'll live with it', 'I'm glad to be back . . . on holidays I get bored easily. . . but now I'm back into the routine and everything is okay'.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

The status dimension

The transition to senior school traditionally entailed elevation to an elite status, of being set apart. Senior school status was an iconic concept the possession of which was desired by students throughout their junior years. Many students in the first cohorts of the New Model felt that this prized status had been eroded. Previously, an important tangible sign of being set apart within the school was the Senior Centre, a place in the Traditional Model reserved for senior students – 'it was our little space… where we could get away from everyone else in the school'. This physical separation from the junior school was much anticipated by students – 'you look forward to it [Senior Centre] for your whole school'. The closure of the Senior Centre while contemporaneous with the introduction of the New Model was not the result of the new senior structure; rather it resulted from the Senior Centre being 'trashed' by the previous senior students.

Previously, 'free' periods were also symbolic of a student's senior status, a time when only seniors could access the canteen without queuing with junior students, a time for relaxation. However, because of the reconfiguration of the senior school timetable students no longer had free periods. 'Early finishing Wednesdays' also disappeared; in the Traditional Model 'seniors never used to get sport, but they used to get to go home and they have every second Wednesday off, we don't get that'. Participation in the school's peer support programme in which seniors mentored Year 7 students in the transition to high school was also no longer possible because of timetable changes. In the past this support programme was popular with senior students not only because it acknowledged their experiential knowledge but also 'a lot of people wanted to do this because you got to go on a camp for four days'. The privileges associated with the Traditional Model tangibly and symbolically represented to senior students and to the school community that becoming a senior student represented a significant school transition. These 'privileges' were seen by students to be eroded by the New Model.

The learning dimension

The intention of the school executive in introducing the New Model was to improve the learning environment in the senior school and thus encourage student engagement with learning, and hence improved retention and final year examination results. Within the new learning environment students identified the following as key influences on their learning: reduced subject load, double lessons, and specifically pedagogical practices in these lessons and the changed classroom demographic.

Reduced subject load. All students affirmed that the reduction of the subject load from six to three subjects per year was the most positive feature of the New Model learning environment. It meant that 'everything doesn't get all muddled up and tangled like when you have six subjects', 'we don't have to juggle subjects so you'll get better marks', 'it's less stress… I think it's really cool' and 'you're only getting half the work that makes you want to stay just that little bit longer'. These comments highlight the benefits seen by students in terms of concentration, less stress and anticipated improved marks. However, a minority of students felt that doing only three subjects was 'boring' because they saw fewer teachers for more hours each day.

Double lessons. Two-hour classes replaced the 50-minute classes of the Traditional Model to ensure students received the BoS stipulated hours per subject. There were a number of reasons why some students preferred the two hour classes – 'we're more occupied' and 'I actually really enjoy it because I like finishing the work'. Students who felt the pace was more relaxed commented that

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

the extended time not only enabled them to complete work 'especially when you've got assessments or when you're doing hard stuff' but also 'you have time to chat and do stuff as well'. This relaxed pace also enabled students to have 'a close bond with your teachers… it's made it a lot better to have that relationship', 'you can communicate with your teacher a lot easier so time goes faster'. On a more prosaic level students were not required to change rooms every 50 minutes and this was a positive factor for some.

Not all students found the two hours enhanced the learning environment – 'doubles are shit… feels ways too long… we don't even get any time to stand up or anything', 'it's just really boring, just really annoying'. Students talked about being 'zoned out', with the result that 'people get fidgety and if they get fidgety they disrupt the class'. Many students commented that 'for some subjects it goes on forever' and 'if you don't like the teacher you're stuck with them'; 'it depends on the teacher' and 'seems like a drag'. One student likened it to 'being back in primary school' because students changed classes and teachers less often than they were used to in high school. Students were less positive in classes where teachers did not give them a break during the two hours which meant we 'clashed a bit with the teachers'. Within the temporal space of the two-hour lessons students pinpointed two salient features which shaped their learning environment, one was teacher's individual pedagogical practices and the other was the altered student demographic.

Classroom pedagogy. The data yield evidence of the impact of the extended lessons on students' engagement with learning. Two kinds of responses to the two-hour lessons were identified. The first was what students called 'zoning in' or engaging with the lesson and the second was 'zoning out' or disengaging. Students enumerated the kinds of pedagogies which engaged them, specifically when teachers:

- employed 'mixed up' pedagogies. Students described these as classes in which they were engaged in multiple activities, such as using technology, doing quizzes;
- responded to individual student's needs, 'they come round and help us';
- gave students short, recuperative breaks;
- encouraged collaborative work 'where we help each other';
- paced the lesson 'not trying to rush everything'.

When these features defined the learning environment students developed close, meaningful relationships with teachers.

> You get to know your teacher more, so you respect them more, I guess, because you're with them a long period of time… it makes a good student–teacher relationship, makes it easier on yourself and them.

Students also commented that they felt closer to other students because 'you feel more comfortable in the class and you're closer to the kids'. The reason for this increased closeness it was suggested was because 'it's kind of more homely… you're more relaxed… it's friendlier, there's more a kind of a bond'. This dual closeness also had an impact on student attendance, 'I come to school even when I'm sick… I don't want to let the teachers down.'

Students were disengaged and 'zoned out' when teachers:

- employed a single learning and teaching activity. The most disengaging activity identified across the interviews was what students called 'constant writing';

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

- failed to pace the lesson with the result that 'like we're constantly doing new topics' and the plea from these students was 'slow things down a little bit';
- refused to allow breaks and told students to 'toughen up and get on with it'. Students indicated that without a break from 'cramming… you just get bored and unmotivated'. The result of this was that 'you get disrupters'.

It is not intended here to analyse teachers' responses to the New Model; this is the focus of a separate article currently under development. It is, however, apposite to report the metaphors teachers employed to describe their pedagogical practices. The metaphors fall into two principal categories: the 'engaging them lesson' and the fast-paced, pressurized 'boom done!' lesson. What is evident from the data is that students' 'zoning in' corresponded to the 'engaging them lesson' and 'zoning out' to the 'boom done!' lessons.

Teachers who adopted the 'engaging them lesson' recognized 'you can only teach kids for so long' and 'students have to be sustained and engaged'. In order to do this you 'just mix it up for them a bit'.

> The teacher and the student can't stay focused for two hours. It's pretty hectic and I do a few silly exercises. Other times I say to them, 'look, got to get this done… so just man up'. But I also do trivia questions, Pictionary, Powerpoints and stretching and breathing techniques.

These teachers acknowledged, as did the students themselves, that if students are not engaged 'they'll switch off'.

In the 'boom done!' lesson teachers relied on didactic pedagogies and described their lessons as 'punching out very rapidly', 'jamming it', 'I just bombard and bombard' and 'you've got to bloody do it [keep the lesson moving]'. One teacher compared the two hour classes to 'the immersion model of language learning'. In this environment these teachers expected students 'to harden up and get on with it' and one teacher considered that 'they don't need breaks; that is rubbish'.

Classroom demographic. The second salient feature of the extended lessons was the changed classroom demographic. In the Traditional Model students remained in the same cohort from Year 7 to Year 12. In the New Model, because students sat examinations in both Senior Year 1 and Senior Year 2, classes were composed of two different cohorts. For example, in an English class there would be novice students who had not sat for any HSC examinations as well as experienced students who had sat examinations in the previous year in subjects other than English. One student described the situation in these terms – 'the classes used to travel around together and they didn't vary very much but now they do… so the classes are kind of scattered'.

Many of the novice students felt unwelcome in some classes because 'they [the experienced students] don't say nothing, just by their facial expression', 'they think they're more significant than we are… they think we are annoying'. They also commented that what also distinguished many of the experienced students was their attitude to learning.

> They're really quiet and just listen kind of thing and all that stuff… They keep to themselves really and we just muck around. They're like, 'we've been through the HSC, we know have serious it is'.

This student continued with the observation that she knew 'it was serious but let's have a bit of fun'. Another issue raised was that of age which was seen as a barrier to communication – 'you don't really like to talk to an older person just in case they think something different; it's a bit more

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

nerve-racking when they're somewhat older'. There were classes, however, where students commented that the two groups 'mixed well' when the experienced students were seen to be 'pretty much the same'. However, it was more common for students to 'just go with our own year'.

Many of the experienced students also felt it was 'strange' to have 'different' students in their group.

> It just feels weird because they're never been there before, but I think it's a good thing. I think some of them are a bit intimidated by us because some of the teachers told them that if they muck up we would have a go at them. There's little groups of us and them.

However, other students commented that it was 'just too difficult to get to know new students' in their final year of school and they felt uncomfortable in the new blended classes.

> Last year you knew everybody in the class and it was easy and it felt comfortable; you could ask questions and you didn't even worry if you thought they were stupid. I just don't feel comfortable any more.

Because of their HSC experience the Senior Year 2 students realized how important it was to pay attention in class because 'the exams come around so quickly'. Though they admitted that they may have 'mucked around a bit last year', now with the last three examination subjects looming they were afraid that the Senior Year 1 students would 'muck around' and this would impact on their own learning.

> They think they're in Year 10 still and they act crazy. They will ruin our learning. I don't like having the younger ones in the class they're stuck up. The boys are all crazy and crap, you try and concentrate and you can't. They just don't listen and they don't concentrate and they talk all the time and they think it's kind of a joke we don't get very much work done because the teacher is trying to tell them to shut up. They think they are so cool and they are so not.

Overall students agreed that classes were 'kinda split' and this was reflected in the seating within the classroom where Senior Year 2 students claimed 'we're the oldest and we should get to choose where we sit; back seats have always been for the seniors'. More importantly, however, Senior Year 2 students felt that some Senior Year 1 students had a negative impact on their learning. Nonetheless, some of the experienced students commented that 'it's surprising how well we bond in some classes'.

Discussion

The senior students interviewed at Grange said they 'looked forward to' becoming seniors from their initial transition to high school. They gleaned what it would mean to become a senior from observations of and conversations with current senior students. In this way by Year 10 students had acquired 'knowledge about' the senior culture, its privileges, symbols and associated status. This traditional culture was the one they anticipated transitioning into after the summer vacation at the end of Year 10. Indeed, many students saw not only the long summer vacation but the traditional Year 11 as a transitional period. The traditional culture informed students 'how to go'; it provided them with recipes, plans and rules (Geertz, 1973) for the final years of their secondary schooling. As Stopl and Smith (1995) argue people become attached to traditions and rituals and if these are modified without regard to their feelings this may result in unease and antipathy. The attachment experienced by the research participants to the senior culture was anticipatory but this did not lessen their disappointment with the cultural changes engendered by the New Model.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

Student dissatisfaction began when they were not consulted during the initial discussions about what the executive saw as a need for cultural change. What was not acknowledged by the school in the initial stages of the change process is the importance of creating a collaborative culture within the school which, Mortimore, Sammons, Stoll, Lewis, and Ecob (1988) suggest, enhances learning. Students were not seen in the school discussion as 'expert witnesses' (Rudduck & Flutter, 2000, p. 81) or as viable partners within the change process. In its well-intentioned improvement initiative Grange was not, to use Rudduck's (2001, p. 7) terminology, 'a listening school' in terms of acknowledging student voice. As a result of the lack of consultation the students felt like 'lab rats' and the 'targets of change' (Hargreaves & Shirley, 2009, p. 26) to whom experiments were done and in which they had no ownership. The 'lab rat' concept was widely known within the school during the transition process but this critical affective component of student responses to change was not addressed by the change managers. This dismissal of affective outcomes is consistent with the findings of Stoll and Fink (1994). As a consequence students suspected the motives of the school executive and had little initial confidence in the new senior structure which 'robbed' them of their anticipated status.

Students explained that the New Model resulted in an immediate loss of status and privileges, such as the anticipated long, summer break which for them was a critical component of transition to the senior school. Students felt that they had lost their 'ranking', which was manifest in tangible symbols such as: the territorially exclusive Senior Centre; the senior free periods in which previously seniors could be observed by others 'relaxing in the playground'; and the loss of recognition of their experiential expertise acknowledged previously through participation in the school peer support programme. In removing these symbols students believed the New Model denied them the means of presenting their elite status to the school population as they were denied the accepted 'spaces' where they could perform their senior status.

The day-to-day rescheduling resulting from the New Model disrupted a timetable which for students had remained unchanged since Year 7. Stopl and Smith (1995) acknowledge the importance of such changes which affect almost all student activities. Students found that the unheralded introduction of two-hour lessons seriously disrupted their learning for two reasons: the didactic pedagogical practices of some of their teachers and the changed classroom demographic which necessitated forging a new classroom identity which would differentiate the 'novice' seniors from the 'examination tested' seniors. During interviews, students in this research did reveal themselves as expert witnesses of classroom learning and teaching and provided valuable information regarding the pedagogical practices which engage them and enhance their relationship with teachers and other students and hence enhance their learning. Students provided vivid evidence of the things that disengage them and the consequences for themselves and for others when they were disengaged.

However, consistent with the findings of Stoll and Fink (1994) and Fullan (1991) initial interviews with teachers indicate a strong resistance to listening to students particularly when students express opinions about teachers' pedagogical practices. One reason for this resistance can be explained by the impact of high stakes testing on teachers' pedagogical practices. Most teachers of senior classes at Grange conceptualize teaching as 'syllabus delivery' for external examination. The syllabus delivery and didactic approach was particularly evident in teachers who taught the more academic classes. Teachers of lower-stream classes where students were not sitting HSC examinations were more responsive to student feedback and exhibited more flexible teaching practices. (These issues are more fully explored in a companion article currently under development.) Another reason for teachers' resistance to listening to students is the strongly held belief by a majority of teachers interviewed that students were not sufficiently mature. That is, teachers generally subscribed to Grace's (1995, p. 202) 'ideology of immaturity'.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

Senior students not only struggled with the practicalities of the new culture but more importantly the New Model has problematized senior student identity which still remains, at the time of the research, 'organizationally embedded' (Holstein & Gubrium, 2000, p. 165) in the traditional culture. Within the new senior context students were required to hone a new situated identity and test out the 'repertoire of identities' (Berger, 1966, p. 107) embedded in the new senior context. Students must now find new ways of actualizing their identity as senior students and uncover ways of displaying this identity both to themselves and to the school community; students must negotiate and craft a new senior identity. Forging a new identity is always part of any transition process mainly because within the new environment individuals have no identity and can be 'lost in the crowd', a crowd with whom they must interact (Scanlon et al., 2007, p. 223).

Students whilst not included in the consultative process have through the current research been, as it were, consulted post facto on the consequences for them of the cultural change that is the New Model. It is critical that the information provided by students be considered by teachers and the executive if the outcomes desired by the executive are to be attained. It is after all students in partnership with teachers who produce these outcomes.

The article has examined the changing senior school experience from the perspective of the first two cohorts of students in the New Model at Grange High. This longitudinal project will continue to interview new cohorts of senior students and explore their perspective of the New Model and the extent to which the New Model itself can, over time, be transformed into a new, Traditional Model. At this stage of the research the most common feeling amongst students can be expressed thus: 'the traditional system is the traditional system, it's what everything is made to fit'. However, it can be said that overall the vast majority of students approved of the New Model in terms of the reduced subject load. Even the extended lessons were endorsed by most students when teachers engaged them through a range of different pedagogies. It is only by giving voice to students that schools can capture the 'vast diversity that exists among students' (Zhao, 2011, p. 268) and give students some measure of control of their learning environment. This is particular apposite for senior students who are in the process of gaining independence and greater control over their out-of-school lives.

References

Anderson, L. W., Jacobs, J., Schramm, S., & Splittgerber, F. (2000). School transitions: Beginning of the end or a new beginning. *International Journal of Educational Research*, *33*(4), 325–339.

Barth, R. S. (2002). The culture builder. *Beyond Educational Leadership*, *59*(8), 6–11.

Baumeister, R. F., & Muraven, M. (1996). Identity as adaptation to social, cultural, and historical context. *Journal of Adolescence*, *19*, 405–416.

Berger, P. (1966). Identity as a problem in the sociology of knowledge. *European Journal of Sociology*, *7*(1), 105–115.

Berger, P., & Luckmann, T. (1966). *The social construction of reality: A treatise in the sociology of knowledge*. London: Penguin.

Crotty, M. (1998). *The foundations of social research*. Los Angeles, CA: SAGE.

Demetriou, D., & Wilson, E. (2010). Children should be seen and heard: The power of student voice in sustaining new teachers. *Improving Schools*, *13*(1), 54–69.

Demetriou, D., Goalen, P., & Rudduck, J. (2000). Academic performance, transfer, transition and friendship: Listening to the student voice. *International Journal of Educational Research*, *33*, 425–441.

Fielding, M. (2001). Beyond the rhetoric of student voice: New departures or new constraints in the transformation of 21st century schooling? *Forum*, *43*(2), 100–110.

Fullan, M. (1991). *The new meaning of educational change*. New York: Teachers College Press.

Fullan, M. (1992). *Successful school improvement*. Buckingham, UK: Open University Press.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015

Geertz, C. (1973). *The interpretation of cultures*. New York: Basic Books.
Grace, G. (1995). *School leadership: Beyond educational management*. London: Falmer.
Hargreaves, A., & Shirley, D. (2009). *The fourth way: The inspiring future for educational change*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Corwin.
Holstein, J., & Gubrium, J. (2000). *The self we live by*. New York: Oxford University Press.
Hopkins, D., & Reynolds, D. (2001). The past, present and future of school improvement: Towards the third age. British Educational Research Journal, 27(4), 459-475.
Leitch, R., & Mitchell, S. (2007). Caged birds and cloning machines: How student imagery 'speaks' to us about cultures of schooling and student participation. *Improving Schools*, *10*(1), 53–71.
Levin, B. (2000). Putting students at the centre of educational reform. *Journal of Educational Change*, *1*, 155–172.
Lingard, B. (2005). Socially just pedagogy in changing times. *International Studies in Sociology of Education*, *15*(2), 165–186.
McGregor, G. (2011). Educating Gen Y in schooling: The need for an egalitarian ethos of education. *Pedagogy, Culture and Society*, *19*(1), 1–20.
Markus, H., & Nurius, P. (1986). Possible selves. *American Psychologist*, *41*, 954–969.
Mortimore, P., Sammons, P., Stoll, L., Lewis, D., & Ecob, R. (1988). *School matters: The junior years*. Shepton Mallet, Somerset, UK: Open Books.
Reezigt, G. J., & Cremmers, P. M. (2005). A comprehensive framework for effective school improvement. *School Effectiveness and Improvement*, *16*(4), 407–424.
Rudd, K., & Gillard, J. (2008). *Quality education: The case for an education revolution in our schools*. Canberra: Australian Commonwealth Government.
Rudduck, J. (2001). Students and school improvement: Transcending the cramped conditions of the time. *Improving Schools*, *4*(2), 7–16.
Rudduck, J., & Flutter, J. (2000). Pupil participation and pupil perspective: 'Carving a new order of experience'. *Cambridge Journal of Education*, *30*(1), 75–89.
Scanlon, L. (2011). 'Becoming' a professional. In L. Scanlon (Ed.), '*Becoming' a professional: An interdisciplinary study of professional learning* (pp. 13–32). Dordrecht, The Netherlands: Springer.
Scanlon, L., Rowling, L., & Weber, Z. (2007). 'You don't have like an identity … you are just lost in a crowd': Forming a student identity in the first year transition to university. *Journal of Youth Studies*, *10*(2), 223–241.
Schutz, A. (1970). *On phenomenology and social relations*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
Stoll, L., & Fink, D. (1994). School effectiveness and school improvement: Voices from the field. *School Effectiveness and School Improvement*, *5*(2), 149–177.
Stoll, L., & Fink, D. (1996). *Changing our schools*. Milton Keynes: Open University Press.
Stolp, S., & Smith, S. C. (1995). Transforming school culture. ERIC Clearinghouse on Educational Management, University of Oregon.
Woods, P. (1996). *Researching the art of teaching*. London: Routledge.
Zhao, Y. (2011). Students as change partners: A proposal for educational change in the age of globalization. *Journal of Educational Change*, *12*(2), 267–279.
Zion, S. (2009). Systems, stakeholders, and students: Including students in school reform. *Improving Schools*, *12*(2), 131–134.

Downloaded from imp.sagepub.com at NORTHERN ARIZONA UNIVERSITY on May 26, 2015